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Pug Horton

Joanne "Pug" Horton fell in love with jazz and blues through recordings of American artists which managed to reach her home in northern England. Inspired by Bessie Smith, Pug began singing blues and classic jazz with local bands and she has remained deeply involved throughout her life. She has participated in numerous recordings with her husband, Bob Wilber, often creating lyrics for his original compositions and acting as a Mistress of Ceremonies for live performances. Together they have created musical tributes to some of America's greatest jazz artists, including Benny Goodman and Sidney Bechet.

Pug was interviewed in Clinton, New York on May 22, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are interviewing at Hamilton College for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Pug Horton here on campus, here for a great weekend with her husband, Bob Wilber, receiving an honorary degree.

PH: An honorary doctorate.

MR: Yes, an honorary doctorate, and Doctor Wilber will be receiving—

PH: Yes. Don't call him any Doc.

MR: No Doc. That's not quite complete. You've seen the music business from a number of sides as a performer yourself, and now as managing and getting in to the logistics of moving around the world in music. Was there a time in your youth when you said I really want to be in music? At what point did you think that that might be possibility?

PH: Do you know I don't think I ever planned my life to begin with. I wish I could say that I had made big plans. But what happened to me was I was a kid growing up in the north of England, and of course jazz is not indigenous to the north of England. And I heard a recording of Bessie Smith. And all I can say, Monk, is that I didn't understand. If you remember on that "Back Water Blues" and she sings "when it rains five days/and the sky turns black as night" I didn't even know, really, what she said. When it rains five days and the sky turns black as night. I'd never heard anything like it. It was like a riveting sound. And I knew that I wanted to do something that would bring me closer to learning more about what was going on there. I knew there was something very special happening. And then I listened to Jelly Roll Morton's original "Jelly Roll Blues" and I got hooked on jazz. But I never really saw myself as being a part of it. I mean I just went with the flow, and I did everything that came along you know. And if it required sort of singing a song for some show or something, that's what I'd do or I'd dance. And sort of to sing some chorus on "Ice Cream" or something like that you know, was kind of fun. And I became a devotee of jazz music, which was rather interesting because there were very few devotees

MR: You anticipated my next question. Were you kind of a club of one?

PH: No. As a matter of fact we had a rhythm club, and I was eleven years old at the time, and I can remember asking someone just quite recently when Bobby and I were up in the north of England. I said, "Tell me, what was I like when I was eleven?" And this woman said, "You were a cheeky little monkey." I wanted to know everything. For instance we were very square, as jazz fans, and we liked the older type music. We liked King Oliver and we liked Jelly Roll Morton, and I didn't subscribe to the idea of anyone needing music. I thought real jazz, you didn't need music. So that has been a battle royal between Bobby and me all these years. I didn't see the sense in that and it was all too glib or too clever. I wanted to have that wonderful ensemble playing that you had in the King Oliver band with all these horns all playing away, and that wonderful spirit, but not have it strained, that purity of it by sort of having to learn too much about it. I equated that. And so we had rather an active rhythm club, but it was very square. I don't think we branched out beyond 1929. I think probably "Weatherbird" was probably as late as we went with that recording.

MR: Were records harder to get in the north of England at the time?

PH: Oh, interestingly enough, there was a guitar/banjo player called Diz Disley in England, and he worked with Stephane Grappelli and he was a great Django devotee. And I remember he had sent for some records from the United States. And one record in particular was Bunk Johnson, the "Tishamingo Blues." And we wanted a record player to play this record on. And we still used rose needles, rose thorns at the time you know, you used a rose thorn for the record. Did you know that?

MR: Oh, I hadn't heard about that.

PH: Oh my dear, I can tell you stories. In any case, I remember walking at least — and we discussed this recently, Diz and I — at least five or six miles on a cold winter's day with a trombone player who had terrible asthma I remember, and he played in sort of the Kid Ory type tailgate trombone between breaths of his asthma, or pants I should say, and we walked miles to go to a house where they had a record player and we could listen to this. And I've never forgotten, never ever forgotten. So we were enormously enthusiastic but totally locked into this brief period of jazz you know.

MR: Was the fact that you had to go through that walking and it was hard to get the records, did it make the music that much more valuable to you do you think?

PH: Oh yes I think it did. And I think because it was not so available it was a mission, it was a mission. And you felt that you truly achieved something when you had gotten to that point and my God it was great as you knew it was going to be. I can remember listening to that chorus over and over and over again. I mean it still sticks with me, the

"Tishamingo Blues." I mean I want to cry, I'm taken back to when I was eleven years old, lo those many fifty odd years whatever. Yes.

MR: Who was the next vocalist to effect you like Bessie Smith did?

PH: Nobody ever really effected me like Bessie, but I was cognizant of other singers and one was Ethel Waters of course. I admired enormously Ethel Waters because she had great diction. If you'll understand that I couldn't understand what Ma Rainey was saying, and I had trouble with Bessie, I found that with Ethel Waters she had beautiful diction. And then of course Eva Taylor, I loved Eva Taylor's singing. Because Eva had a great sort of clarity to her voice. So I was impressed by these singers. I didn't turn on to Billie Holiday until much, much later in life.

MR: Was there a language, not a barrier but some of the things that Bessie Smith may have sung, even if you understood what she was saying, that there was a new phrase in there that maybe wasn't common to English.

PH: Yeah, we were not hip to a lot of these things, and certainly even today. John Hammond was very kind to me and he gave me quite a lot of music of Bessie's. And I was pleased to see in some of the written words, the words that I'd been singing, lyrics I'd been singing, that everybody sort of who'd been singing. You know a lot of the singers who sing the Bessie Smith material had been singing incorrect words. Just sort of you made them up as an educated guess. But there are certainly words that were indigenous not to the north of England, and I felt a bit corny, a bit of a fake singing them, because I didn't have any frame of reference for singing that. And I didn't know about "my man done gone left me" and so on, and I didn't know about the "achin' head" because I was too young to have had a "achin' head." But I knew she was saying something that was reaching me. And it was an unusual voice. And Bessie had great purity in her voice. I'm not talking about the last record she made, I'm talking about the first record she made with the Bessemer Singers. She had almost a holy voice but she was not a Gospel singer. I want to make that point right up front. Today's singers that want to sing like Bessie always introduce Gospel. Bessie was not. She didn't have any Gospel in her voice at all. I'm adamant about that.

MR: I think it's so great that Bessie Smith lands in the north of England and falls on someone's ears like that. I just love that story.

PH: Well I think it's unusual. I mean my father said, "She's jazz crazy you know." And I can remember going to someone's home and she'd bought some records, she had a brother in the RAF or something like that, and invited me to go around, and I sort of, I remember going into the house, and the girl's father was sitting there having his tea, which is like dinner for us, for the working man. And he was sitting there sort of digging into his tea

doing this kind of thing. I mean and this man's looking at me like I had descended from another planet. I mean again, they didn't understand. Because jazz music was really a very esoteric type of sound. We've had good bands incidentally in England. I mean don't forget that Coleman Hawkins and the Ramblers, the Dutch Ramblers and stuff, the big bands of the '30s, Henry Hall, Ambrose Roy Fox, Jack Hilton and so on, had some very good bands, and they had good support from the American musicians that chose to come over there. You know, Coleman Hawkins and Benny Carter.

MR: Do you recall what kind of music your parents listened to?

PH: Oh yes. My father's favorite songs, one of the songs he sang was "The Music Goes Round and Round" and comes out here. My mother liked possibly the songs of Gracie Fields and sort of the songs that were on the radio. It was mostly the popular music of the '30s, Noel Coward and so on. Interestingly enough, we are very, Bobby and I listen to a lot of Gracie Fields. When Bob was asked about his favorite singers he said — not in jazz — one was Janet Baker and the great English — I suppose you'd call her an opera singer. And the other is Gracie Fields. And Gracie Fields didn't have any musical training but has an incredible voice. And so that's the kind of music that I was raised on. And that's what my parents listened to.

MR: So did you need to search out other musicians a few years later, so that you could get to sing?

PH: No because suddenly, don't forget this was getting into the late 40s, and just after the war, and we were starting to have these bands sprouting up, all having listened to records and not always the best records because we had this rose thorn don't forget that took a lot away from the fidelity, and so everybody was mad to play like all of these bands that they had heard. So there was a lot of opportunity to sing around with mostly university students who subsequently either went on to become doctors, lawyers or indeed some of them, like Monty Sunshine or Chris Barber, Ken Collier, did form bands and did become quite successful, very successful in the jazz business in England.

MR: Do you recall some of the first tunes that you sang with these bands?

PH: Well of course I sang "Ice Cream," I sang "Baby Doll," which is very sophisticated, Bessie Smith's "Baby Doll," "Young Woman Blues," "Careless Love Blues," "Alexander's Ragtime Band" with the verse because that was so marvelous. I think there was a mistake on the original recording and they never cleared it up and I always thought that was fascinating. And then I sang a lot of things that really didn't seem related to jazz but I felt that there was a possibility of making them in the idiom, which I still do with Bob. I take a song that I've heard that you can make it sound like Bessie could have sung it if she'd have known. I mean for instance, Bud Freeman once told us that he heard

[sings] See you in my dreams, you know, it would have worked. And apparently according to Chris Albertson, who wrote the definitive book on Bessie, that she sang "Smoke Gets In Your Eyes," and I don't doubt it because people were required to sing all kinds of material.

MR: Well that gives a whole different spin to the lyrics of "I'll See You In My Dreams" to see it like that.

PH: Yes it does. But I think that you can, if you think about all the great songs that there's a way of hearing them and thinking. Bob has always said if Benny [Goodman] didn't play this he should have done it.

MR: What circumstances brought you to the United States?

PH: First of all I came to live in Canada in the '50s. I suppose in a way you could say that I was importing husbands but I'm not really. I came over with my first husband, who was an actor, and we went to live in Canada, and I was working for CBC, I was very active. I was doing a weekly television show, and not singing, I was acting. I was performing and acting as a showgirl and one thing or the other. Then I went back to England, after doing quite a lot of work, I played a small part in a Frank Sinatra movie, and I did a lot of things, living in Florida, and then I went back to England, and couldn't seem to settle there. And I married an Englishman who'd been a resident in medicine in Albany, New York and we came back over here. And he was a trombone player, played with a jazz band, and we had a very good jazz band in Albany, New York, for a long time and I sang with that and for twelve and a half years we had a band, very actively playing around, and played a lot of material, and I did a number of festivals. And then we broke up and Bobby and I went off together, and we've been together twenty-one years now, which is a long time, although I wish I had it all to do again, I'd have twenty-one more. In any case, it's —

MR: Were you aware of Bob Wilber's music before you met?

PH: Oh yes. I can remember being in my grandmother's kitchen. My grandmother lived in a working class type of cottage, and she had one small mirror, and it was sort of what men use for shaving you know, they would shave over the kitchen sink you see like this. And I remember putting on this green head scarf, it was very popular in those days to wear a head scarf and you sort of made it look very sheik and so on, and I can remember looking at myself in the mirror and then my eye catching an article from the *Melody Maker,* which was the — mostly jazz in those days, it's not anymore sadly — and there was an article and it said Sidney Bechet takes on a young student from Scarsdale. And I thought to myself that's who I want. And I was fifteen.

MR: Get out.

PH: No. I was 15 years old, and I can remember looking at myself in the mirror and thinking, oh yes, you look kind of cute you know in this thing, and looking at this photograph, that's what I want. That's the first time. And I said I'm not being contrary, but when I said I didn't plan my life, that's when I said something that I wanted. And I wrote to Bob. I wrote to the Commodore Music Shop and said, "I know you know everybody, could you get me some autographs and photographs?" And Bob apparently said he didn't get the letter but whether he did or not he subsequently said that he did. But I was fascinated by him, always fascinated by him, always. And although we had a number of meeting, he would come to our summer house in Saratoga when I was married to my former husband, and we would see each other as friends with no thought at all of any escapade, we just loved to talk about jazz. It was like a dream come true to be with somebody that you felt you already knew so well, and I admired him. I admired this young man who could have gone any route, and he denied his parents their ambition for him, to go off and be a jazz musician you know. I didn't realize that jazz musicians had three or four square meals a day and slept in lovely beds with nice clean sheets and everything. I thought it was all like really the blues. I mean when I read *Really the Blues*, I read it surreptitiously, like you'd read Henry Miller you know? I was sort of hoping that no one was going to see what you were reading. I mean I thought it was that naughty.

MR: Sometimes it is, but not always.

PH: No but I was thinking that it was always, that all jazz musicians were the way that they were portrayed by Mezz Mezzrow. And it's not so.

MR: Right. You seem to make a good pair. And I know over the twenty years you've had quite a significant hand in Bob's career. Did you, when you first got into trying to further his career, was it a steep learning process for you, of how to negotiate contracts and how to open avenues? How to get him in other parts of the world that he hadn't been in before?

PH: No. Because tenacity is my middle name. And I felt when I got to know Bob better, that he was far more — he was deserving of far more than he'd actually achieved. When he was young he had a lot of acclaim with The Wildcats and with the bands that he had, and I think he went into a sort of period of what I thought was something semi-obscurity, which I thought was unfair, and I thought that we had to dig really fast in order to make up for lost time. And at that point I took on a lot of chores that I didn't expect to take on, but because I felt that he was worth it, and I felt that the world should know how worth it he was. That's my role in life I think. I mean I can sing, I can get up and sing, Bob always laughs, he says she doesn't need to rehearse you know. I mean I'll tackle "Lush Life" or anything you want me to sing, but I'm much more interested in being a husband

to me. I wrote four grants for him to the NEA and got them for him, because I felt that he certainly is passing on a legacy, just as one was passed on to him. I think that Hamilton in bestowing this honorary doctorate on him have done a very wise thing. I know they'll never regret it. And so for me, life has always been hurdles. I love them. I think that it's just something to do. I mean you don't just look at it and say well what should we do, you get on with it. And I think that's part of my north country upbringing. I think Marian McPartland, I mean I know you endowed her with an honorary doctorate, Marian is from the same kind of stock you know. You don't just stand there. I mean we English have had to stand up to a lot. And so Bob was a challenge and Bob's career was challenge to me. I didn't know how to deal with all these things, but you learn. We all had the tools.

MR: Well said. Did you run into various degrees of honesty and dishonesty in agents in booking him in different parts?

PH: I ran into a lot of animosity, I should say that, because people are jealous and deeply threatened and particularly because Bob is a Piscean and he's a very gentle man, and people couldn't understand why he was suddenly getting so taciturn and hard-nosed you know. And a lot of the time it was his idea, but it was me that was probably blamed. And as far as that was concerned I suppose it made us closer together, which was wonderful. As far as agents are concerned, I think that agents are in a very untenable position. I think they have to be dishonest even though it's not their nature, because if they were to tell you that they don't have any work, you'd go somewhere else. You parallel it to a builder that comes to your house. If he gives you a price that it's really going to cost, you're going to say I'm sorry I can't afford it and you'll send him on his way. If he tells you it's going to cost less, and tells you little fibs, little fibs or big fibs, you will give him the job and then he can't do it, and so on and so forth. It's an untenable situation, Monk, and it's one that happens all the time. I don't put it down to dishonesty. I put it down to the fact that it's an overcrowded profession. Not necessarily overcrowded with talented people. I think there's a lot of untalented people who are getting work but that's another issue, that's not what I'm interested in. The fact is, there's only so much work. And for agents, they can only provide you with so many gigs. So they might just string you along, not because they're being devious, but because they are having to sort of say everything nice to everybody.

MR: Yeah. We had an earlier conversation about the importance placed on jazz in this country and abroad. Does it make a difference when you go overseas to play, in the response?

PH: Yes it does. Less than it used to, because I think that now it's become commonplace. American musicians are appearing on the doorstep just about every other day. And it's been known for certain musicians from the United States to appear twice in our little

pubs and places like that. It's beneath them, beneath their talent, and I don't approve of them having to do that. But unfortunately it's the only way. If you want to do two tours a year you can't do them both in concert halls you see? I think that now the message has gotten out, and certainly some of the Swedish are brilliant players. Bob's student Antti Sarpila from Finland has a band and is playing all the time. Antti is a phenomenally talented musician. I think that it's taking the edge off the American standard of playing. First of all you have to realize the attrition rate among the legends, in quote legends of jazz, has been very hard on us all, and we've lost so many fine players. And there hasn't been a continuum. The musicians have not been sort of growing up and following in their footsteps and staying with it as Bob has for instance and a number of other people who have been enamored of the music. So there has been a dearth of players to fill those shoes so that now you can go to England and the musicians are picking up with a pianist and a rhythm section so they don't have to take over a rhythm section. I think that there's a great love of the music that's different in other countries, and I think that people are always willing to pay the dues to the United States for having created, being that it has spawned this music. And I think they're delighted that young Johnny is playing along with the jazz records and will no doubt join the school jazz bands, however it sounds. And there are jazz programs starting throughout the United Kingdom, probably in the same way that they are in this country. In Switzerland for instance, there's a great tradition of jazz. For instance when Hans Weber, who is a dear friend and a promoter of jazz, has a jazz festival in May in Berne, you play one day at The Rathskeller, where there are people bringing their babies and these people were brought there by their parents. Now that is exciting, because their parents are familiar with all the musicians they're going to see play, and their children are familiar with it. That's wonderful.

MR: You've got some continuity there, it's really establishing it.

PH: Yes, absolutely. And the same thing applies in other places in England for instance, when people have some frame of reference for what they have seen and they continue to watch and so on. But I think the economics of bringing over musicians is getting harder, and one of the problems that we have, Bobby and I subscribe to as well, is that Bob doesn't like jam sessions. He really likes a formed group, because as you notice from our recordings, we like musicians that have at least shook hands before they go on the stage. They should at least have practiced a couple of things together. And it gets harder, because these musicians are being asked would you like to come over and do two weeks in England or Germany or somewhere, and you arrive at the airport and you're picked up by the promoter and you meet all the musicians and this is Fred and this Jack and this, and so on, and you make whatever music you can make. Well that's fine, that's fine if

you're Jelly Roll Morton or if you're King Oliver or Louis Armstrong or Sidney Bechet. But not everybody is, sad to say.

MR: Do you think it sells the music short?

PH: Yes I do. Yes I do. I think that people think if that's all there is, maybe that is one of the problems that we have today. I mean at least the way that it sounded with the rose hip thorn, the rose thorn, it wasn't great, but at least we were listening to the right stuff. If you're hearing something that's been so adulterated down, down, down, down, down, sort of it's not going to sound as good. And how can you sound — as Bob always says, I quote Bob a lot, but he says you're only as good as the people you play with. And if you're picking up somebody that's just done a ten hour shift down the mine, as diligent and as enthusiastic as he may well be, he's not going to have the same kind of energy to put on a concert and be in sync with you, do you think?

MR: I doubt it. I think of that kind of situation, even at the jazz parties that exist in this country, where all the musicians certainly are of high caliber, but I would prefer at times to hear some—

PH: Organized bands. Well just this past March, Mat Domber did March of Jazz. We had a number of sets. We had some wonderful sets. We had sets with Dave McKenna and Dick Hyman, Antti Sarpila, we had wonderful people. But there's one thing that I just — I cannot speak highly enough of Bob, but he is an organized person. He's organized in his personal life, and he's organized in his musical life, it's one and the same. And before you go on stage there is never a matter of sort of what should we play next. "Undecided" no I don't want to play that — well I don't do it in that key, it's never like that. We all know what we're going to do. There's always a time when Bob probably fumbles trying to get the program out of his pocket and —

MR: That's the extent of that.

PH: Yeah. And we laugh a little bit about that you know. But we know where we're going and what we're going to do, and we like to think of music as being theatre. When Bob was director of the Smithsonian, we put on a theatrical performance. It began with me singing a cappella "Back Water Blues," and then went into "Mournful Serenade." On a darkened stage, Bob would walk out onto a darkened stage and talk about what is jazz, and then would build. And we would do an hour and a half of the whole history of jazz, starting with Bessie Smith and Eva Taylor and we'd start the second half with Duke Ellington and I would do the Ivy Anderson. That's what I did with Bob. Our first gig together was at Carnegie Hall and he asked me to do the music of Ivy Anderson. I said she wasn't really somebody that I had listened to a great deal, and I thought thank you very much, it was nice of him to ask but I wouldn't bother. But I digress on that. I did tell

would go on to Thelonious Monk, Charlie Parker, Dizzy Gillespie, and I would sing something attributed to Sarah Vaughan in her younger days, and close up with I think Count Basie's "Jumpin' at the Woodside." And it was a whole history of jazz. But we presented it as theater. I would wear clothes that depicted the era with Eva Taylor, as Eva would have dressed, and as the stylistic way of Ivy Anderson, who was very elegant, and the way that Sarah Vaughan dressed. I mean it was all theater. We mustn't forget that. It's terribly important, Monk, for a performer to realize there is an audience out there, and I love you, I'm performing for you. Because when you turn your back on them, you've lost them, don't even start. I mean I think it was a man by the name of Morris who wrote *In Search of an Audience Development*, and it's something that's particularly interested me for a long time and still does, and I think we only have ourselves to blame if we don't have an audience. We have to be developing an audience all the time that we're performing. All the time. And we must never, ever forget the fact that they came and bought tickets to see you, so you perform for them. We all perform a service, and that is our service.

MR: Well the greats certainly knew that, Ellington and so on.

PH: You see all those wonderful gestures as the musicians in the brass section and the way they would throw up their horns, and the guys moving, I mean it was wonderful and it was not playing down to the audience in any way, it was a sense of joy. I just love it. I love to bring people in. I think it's fantastic. And it's amazing, when we did this performance we did something and I acknowledged Connie Haines and Louise Tobin out in the audience, and I sang a song for them, I sang Billy Strayhorn's "A Flower is a Lovesome Thing." And that sells itself, you know, you just stand there and sing the song, but there are other songs when you know that it's essential to bring the people in. It is performing. And I think that a lot of today's younger players — it distresses me to say this — that I think they're not cognizant of performing, and they don't have smiles on their faces. I remember Zoot Sims once said to me, "Don't ever, ever, ever sing 'Rocks in my Bed' with a smile on your face." He was right, but I think that there is a way of having passion or having some feeling in your face, not a vacuous stare.

MR: Over the years, did you ever run into any racial — I don't know exactly what the word would be—

PH: Reverse prejudice?

MR: Yeah.

PH: I suppose you know I've only been blonde for a few years since I started to go gray. I used to be very, very dark. In fact when Gus Johnson met me for the first time he believed that I was black. And I have very dark skin. And I don't know whether, I don't

been times when I've read articles about people not liking a singer because they were of a different colored persuasion you know? But it's never actually happened to me. I don't believe so. I've worked with performers and I roomed with Maxine Sullivan and I never felt it, and I don't think anyone ever made me feel conscious of it. The fact that John Hammond — Hank O'Neil once said "you're the only singer that John Hammond ever said anything nice about except for the ones that he really loved, Billie and Bessie." He said to Hank, "Have you heard this girl, Pug Horton?" And Hank said, "No I haven't." He said, "She's all right" which I thought was a very high compliment. And of course I worked with musicians of all color. I mean it didn't bother me so why would it bother them? I mean my heart was in the right place.

MR: Well there seems to be some controversy going on in the last few years about the white musicians' place in jazz today, and whether or not they have usurped the music. And I find it curious that there seems to be very few young black musicians playing what we have come to call classic jazz. At the jazz parties you don't see many.

PH: That is true. But last year when Bob did his tributes to Sidney Bechet and he worked with Wynton Marsalis, all the musicians with Wynton were totally dedicated to what was going on. I think it's because they didn't have an interest in it. It's not that they couldn't do it. And I think maybe now they're becoming more aware of the music. Certainly Michael White loves Johnny Dodds, and would love to play like him. I think that there is also a period of what is young people's music. It's not to do with color, it's to do with what kind of music are young people listening to. Not color. Not black, white, Hispanic, this, Chinese. It's what kind of music are young people listening to. And basically they're not listening to classic jazz. I think that it's part of the era that we're living in. It would be nice if they would accept classic jazz as being part of the history of music, and that should be mandatory. But I blame families, I blame academics for not teaching this. I think there's a lot of teachers who have abrogated the role by not going back far enough, maybe because they themselves didn't know enough about it. And perhaps they were not given good schooling on the early music. They were not taught about the era of Ragtime. They were not taught about the early days of jazz. And as a result you cannot fault the student for not learning. I have believed always that if the student hasn't learned, the teacher has not taught.

MR: Yeah, because we're getting a couple of generations away from that music now, so it gets harder and harder. If the generation right after the music didn't get it, what makes you think the next one's going to? Well you spoke pretty eloquently earlier on about the fact that every generation has its own thing, has to find its own way. I wish we could find a way that the music could be made available, perhaps more available than it is, so that

PH: Well I think that you're going in the right direction, you're certainly going in the right direction here with people like Milt Fillius and what you're doing, Monk. I think certainly. You can encourage. There are a lot of people at Bob's age group who are more than happy to come on to your campus and spend a month doing an Artist in Residency. They are sitting around not necessarily wanting to be running for gigs all the time, but they would be happy to pass on their legacy and to come in and be articulate and talking — not to be threatening the teachers, they're not looking to take over a full time job with tenure at a university. But they would be delighted I think to come in and talk about what it really is like to be a street musician, not just an academic, not somebody who's graduated with a bachelor's degree and taken a job right away. All right?

MR: Good point.

PH: Now. I think that it is possible — you're looking for an answer? I'm going to give you one, all right? I am not a wishy-washy person. I'm going to tell you that you look around the country. There are people who are articulate musicians, who would be happy to give you two weeks of their time, you accommodate them, you treat them as well as you have been treating us, and you say talk to our students. Tell them about the relevance of this music. And you bring in somebody else. And you bring in somebody else. And you bring in somebody else. You can get funding for doing these kinds of things. And I have to say that more often than not — do you know who's going to be more upset than anybody? I don't know whether it's this way here, but I'll tell you on most of the academic campuses we go — are the teachers. Because what you're doing is almost teaching sedition. You are teaching these students, you're telling these students something that maybe is opening up a Pandora's box because baby, the teacher is suddenly out on a limb. He doesn't know maybe about that period perhaps that you're going to talk about. But people shouldn't be threatened. The whole idea of being in teaching is not to be threatened, but to give of your own ability and learn, keep your own ears open. And to have these kids being given every opportunity. Now I know for instance that in Arizona that there are two very good academic programs in music. My husband has not been asked to do anything, even though he'd be happy to go up there and give his time, just to sort of make sure that the legacy is passed on. Why don't they want him? What if he goes in there and tells the real story of what jazz is about? Not some far-reaching fantasy. What if he just goes in there and just says look I'm Bob Wilber and this is what I've done all my life, and there are many other people like him who would be delighted to do this. Wouldn't that be a good idea? Wouldn't that be one way of salvaging what is left, and hoping that you're going to give jazz music the credibility that it should have, the place in American society is to start with young people. And when young people hear Bob talk, and hear these legends talk,

MR: You said it pretty well. You really did. I think sometimes academics may be threatened by people who have made their living playing the music instead of just teaching about it. That that may be a threat to them. But there are some inroads being made in that.

PH: I'd like to think so. And there are certainly teachers, I mean there's one particular teacher at the University of New Hampshire who is very encouraging and is always getting people like Clark Terry and Bob to go up there and bring his charts and to work with them. And I think that this is one thing that you can do. You can certainly set aside some time. And I think another problem that is part of our society, Monk, is that students are being called upon to give far too many hours for other extracurricular things. That their time is so valuable. I know when Bob is doing other academic programs he would say, "Did you listen to the music? Did you play the music?" They said we haven't had time, we had to do so-and-so, we had to do something else and so on. So I do think that our young people today are being challenged in many ways, and they're having to prioritize. And this is not necessarily something that they're going to go in for. Maybe they're not going to be full time professional jazz musicians, but they could be full time professional musicians or teachers.

MR: And they could be a great audience too.

PH: Yup. Yes indeed.

MR: We need that. Well this has really been fascinating. What's in the near future for you guys?

PH: Well we leave for England on June the first. We go to Silkeborg in Denmark for a wonderful festival which is — now here's the thing — sponsored by Tuborg Beer, which money is no object which is lovely so it shows you where their values are. But nonetheless, we've been going for three years now. We are going to be there with the Bechet legacy as I say with Phil Flanigan and Eddie Metz, Mark Shane and Dave Cliff, a wonderful guitarist from England that we've used a lot, and Eric Jon Kellso, the trumpet player. And then in July Bob is doing a mini-tour with Kenny Davern and we're going to hang out in Juan-les-Pins, just to soak up the air as you would say and just enjoy it. And August we will be in France at festivals and in Toulouse. And then in September we've decided to go into France and look for a place that we thought we'd like to have a little place on the ocean in Normandy so we're going to go and explore, and then we go to Japan with the Statesmen of Jazz, which is the one where Bob is the baby and the oldest member is 96. And then we do a big band cruise in November. And so it brings us to the end of 1998, and a year of semi-retirement.

MR: That's what I was about to say, my God.

PH: But I have to tell you that, I mean not that Bob wants to hurt anyone's feelings, but he

the kind of things that he wants to do, and he's doing it. And we're both doing it and we're enjoying it enormously. We have a very active life with our children and our grandchildren and so on, and next year looks like, with the exception of April when we will be in Paradise Valley and doing concerts in Denver and in Atlanta, I think that we have no work which is wonderful, just the month of April. And it pleases us because it gives us more time just to enjoy picking the grapefruit.

MR: And listening to some of your favorite singers.

PH: That I have very little time to do. But I have to say that when I do there are things that absolutely still knock me out, things, the old things that I've heard over and over and over and over again. I still am totally moved to tears by a lot of the things that I've been listening to for all these years.

MR: I guess that's why they call it classic.

PH: Um hum.

MR: Well it's been great talking to you and I'm so glad you're on the campus here for the weekend. Enjoy the rest of the weekend.

PH: Thank you.

MR: And I hope we run into each other again soon.

PH: I hope so.

MR: Hopefully on a cruise.

PH: Wouldn't that be nice, yes. Thank you, Monk, it was lovely.

MR: Thanks so much.